

Startup Playbook

A Comprehensive Student & Founder Journey Document



Acknowledgement

This Startup Playbook has been created under the initiative of the Board for Student Welfare (BSW), IIT Delhi. We sincerely thank the BSW team for their guidance, collaboration, and commitment to building a student-centric resource. The collective efforts of the team in shaping, refining, and executing this playbook have been instrumental in making it a practical guide for aspiring student entrepreneurs.

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*WE THANK ALL **BSW REPRESENTATIVES** INVOLVED FOR THEIR SUPPORT IN FORMATTING AND FINALIZING THIS GUIDE.*

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Why This Playbook Exists?

A STRONG, COHESIVE SUPPORT SYSTEM

At IIT Delhi, entrepreneurship is supported by a powerful and deeply integrated ecosystem led by the Entrepreneurship Development Cell (eDC) and strengthened by SInC, Genesis, Venture Studio, Kinesis, BECon, Anastomosis, Industry Connect, and FITT. Together, these initiatives ensure that founders receive structured guidance and support at every stage; from the first spark of curiosity to building scalable, impact-driven companies.

This document turns the ecosystem into a clear, journey-driven guide.

NAVIGATING THE STARTUP MAZE

Entrepreneurship is not a straight or predictable path. For most students and first-time founders, it is confusing, uncertain, and often overwhelming.

While many students at IIT Delhi possess strong technical skills and innovative ideas, they frequently struggle with fundamental questions such as where to start, whom to approach, what to build first, and how to avoid common early-stage mistakes.

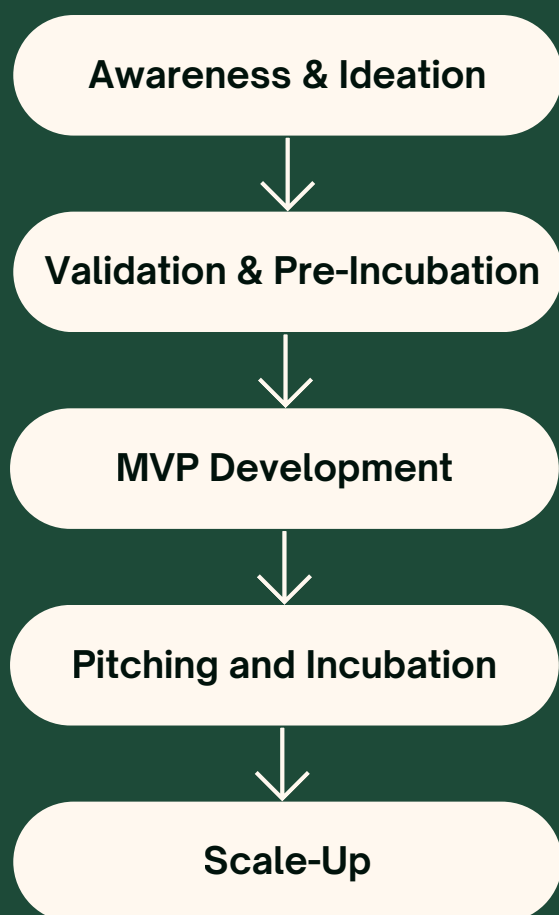
This Startup Playbook exists to remove that lingering confusion.

Ecosystem Philosophy

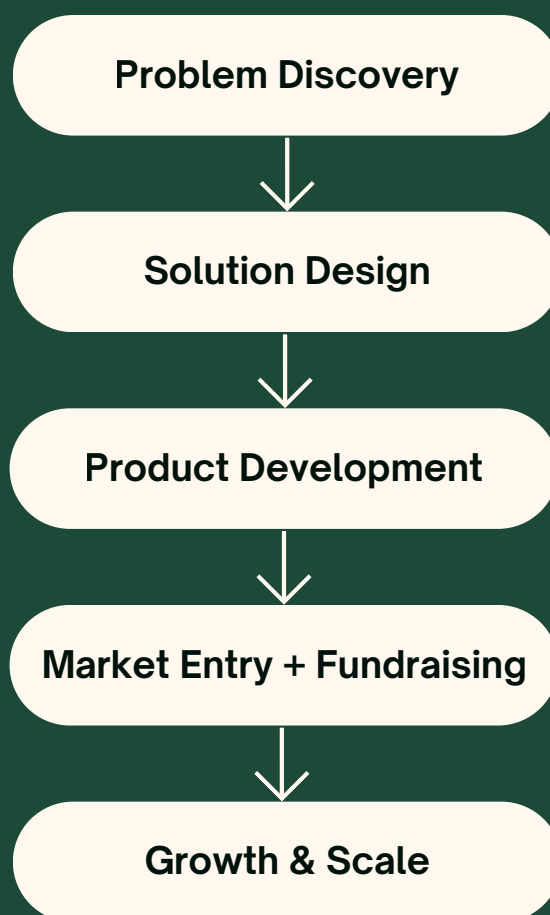
Entrepreneurship at IIT Delhi is approached not as an end goal of company creation, but as a long-term capability developed through sustained exposure, structured experimentation, mentorship, disciplined execution, and continuous reflection.

The ecosystem is designed around two interconnected user journeys:

Student's Journey



Founder's Journey



The eDC focuses on awareness, inspiration, and ecosystem exposure. SInC and execution programs provide hands-on guidance, structure, and accountability. FITT anchors formal incubation, industry integration, and scale.

Ideation and Problem Discovery

What is a business problem? Where can we find a problem?

Entrepreneurship begins with identifying meaningful problems rather than chasing ideas. A strong startup problem typically:

Occurs frequently

Affects a specific group of users

Lacks a satisfactory solution

Causes real inconvenience

Students are encouraged to observe:

Gaps in technology or service delivery

Campus life challenges

Industry inefficiencies

Societal and environmental problems

Inefficiencies in personal routines

Daily life friction

Founder Qualities

What are some founder's qualities. Where we develop initial thinking.

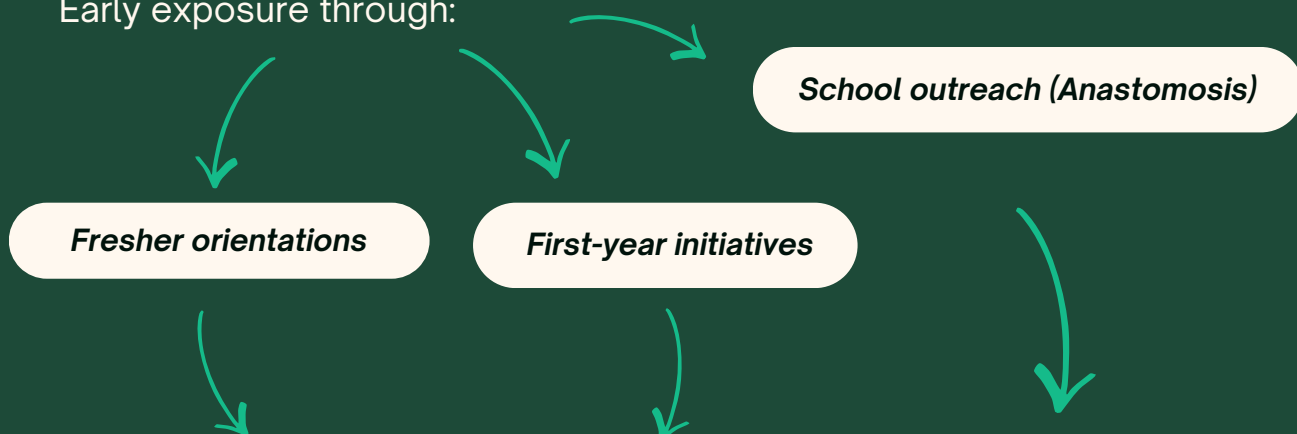
Founders are trained to:



Programs such as Musketeers, eDC workshops, and Kinesis bootcamps help students validate whether a problem is truly worth solving.

Building the Entrepreneurial Mindset

Early exposure through:



*Helps students develop Curiosity, Resilience, Comfort with ambiguity, and Willingness to learn from failure.
This mindset is more important than any single idea.*

Early Execution and Pre-Incubation

THIS STAGE FOCUSES ON:

- Defining the customer clearly
- Clarifying what the solution does and does not do
- Identifying differentiation
- Listing assumptions that require testing

At this stage, clarity is prioritized over speed.

SInC (Student Incubation Cell)

Founders receive: Shared co-working spaces, Internet and infrastructure, Access to labs, institute facilities and a peer founder community

To Contact SInC:

- Contact the team via official email (contact@sinciitd.in).
- Visit the SInC office at the IIT Delhi R&I Park.
- Attend SInC events, orientations, and startup talks.
- Submit your idea through the SInC/FITT application process

Get Mentorship from: IIT Delhi faculty, Alumni entrepreneurs, Industry professionals

FOUNDATIONAL STARTUP DOCUMENTATION:

Teams are guided to create problem statements, customer personas, value propositions, early revenue hypotheses, and execution timelines. This documentation becomes the backbone of future decisions.

Community & Networking

"STARTUPS GROW FASTER WHEN FOUNDERS DON'T GROW ALONE"

Entrepreneurship is mentally demanding, and a strong community provides founders with support, clarity, and momentum. Interacting with peers normalizes failure, builds resilience, and keeps motivation high, while shared goals create accountability.

COMMUNITY PLATFORMS & ACTIVITIES

Hackathons, meetups, discussion sessions, and startup expos help founders rapidly ideate, network, gain insights, and showcase products while connecting with investors and potential collaborators.

PEOPLE POWER

Identify co-founders with shared vision and complementary skills, build early teams that can execute quickly in uncertainty, and access advisors, alumni, and industry experts for strategic guidance.



BECon – The Ecosystem Catalyst

INDIA'S STUDENT STARTUP ENERGY—ON ONE STAGE.

North India's largest student-run entrepreneurship summit, bringing together students, founders, investors, mentors, and policymakers.

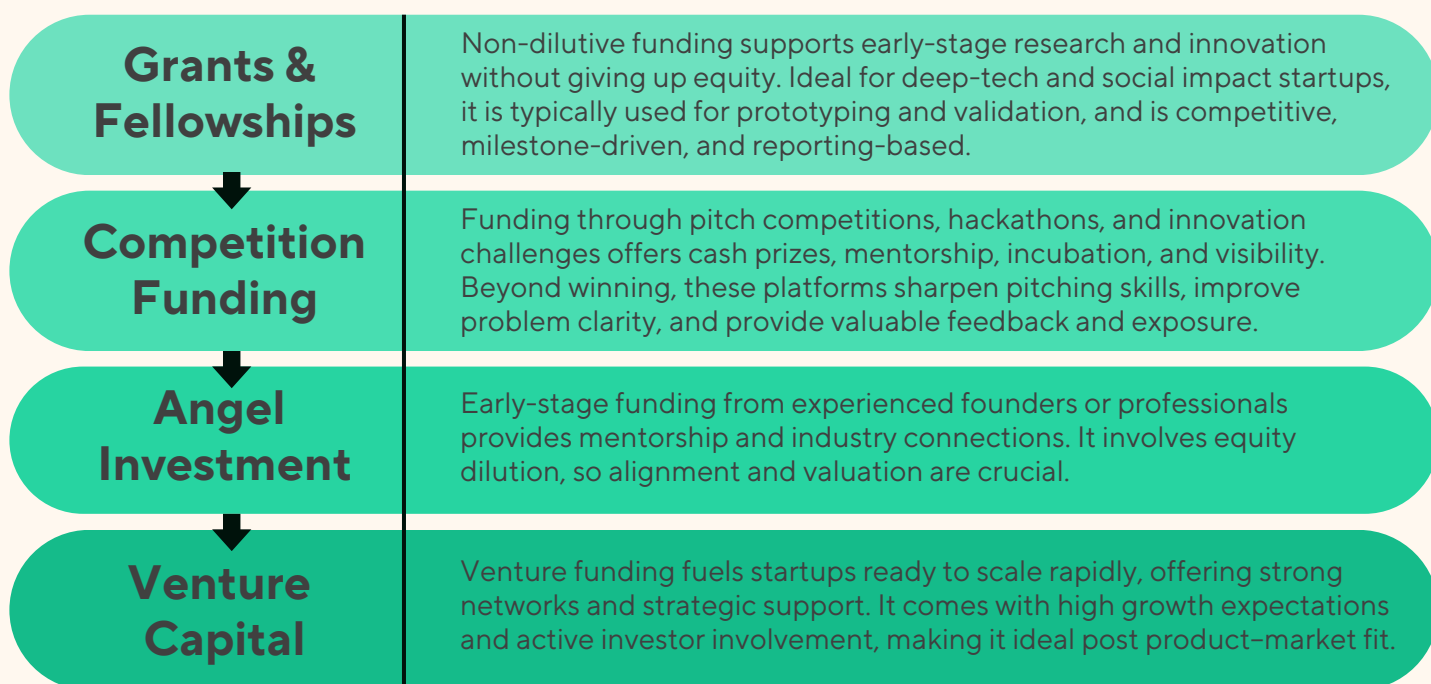
BECon Highlights:

- Keynote Talks: Real startup journeys and practical lessons
- Panel Discussions: Multiple perspectives on trends and challenges
- Pitch Competitions: Idea validation, feedback, and funding exposure
- Hackathons & Startup Expos: Innovation, visibility, and partnerships
- BECon Regionals : City-level editions strengthening local startup communities and linking regional talent to national opportunities

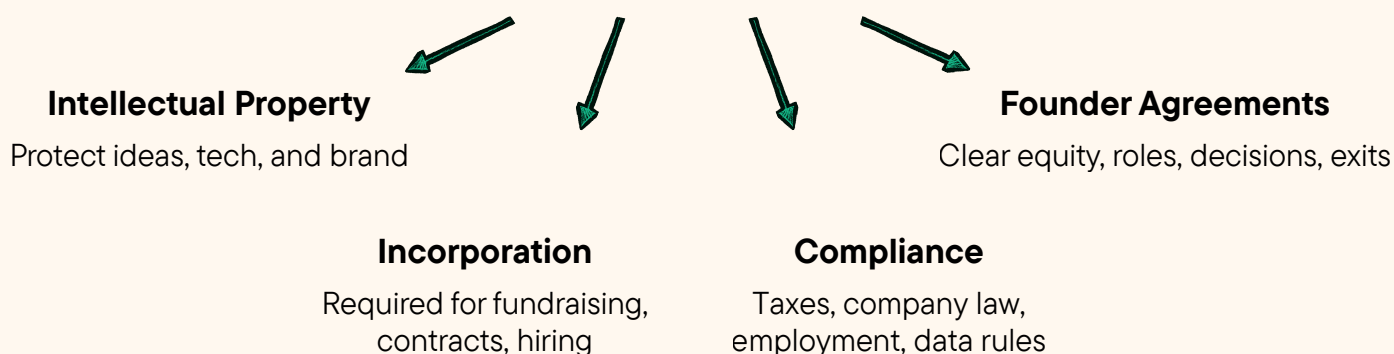
Funding Pathways & Legal Foundations

This equips founders to build smart, secure the right funding, and stay legally protected from day one. It helps them understand funding sources, engage confidently with investors, and establish strong legal foundations—avoiding early conflicts, financial stress, and loss of control.

Different stages need different capital



Legal & Compliance Basics: Strong foundations prevent future cracks



MVP Development

WHAT IS AN MVP?

MVP = MINIMUM VIABLE PRODUCT

An MVP is not a smaller version of the final product. It is a learning tool designed to answer one key question:

Will users actually use this?

STRUCTURED MVP DEV.

To help founders navigate this critical phase, IIT Delhi offers structured, hands-on support through programs such as **Venture Studio** and **Kinesis**.

These initiatives break down MVP development into manageable, outcome-driven components:

Rapid Prototyping

The IIT Delhi ecosystem strongly promotes speed with intention where founders are encouraged to prototype quickly using available technical resources, labs, and collaborative workspaces.

Business Model Creation

Founders are guided to articulate a clear business model alongside product development.

MVP Planning

Rather than attempting to build complete solutions, founders are trained to define the minimum set of features required to test their key assumptions.

Iterating Rapidly

Feedback collected during testing is immediately translated into action. Rapid iteration ensures continuous improvement and reduces the cost of early mistakes.

Go-to-Market Thinking

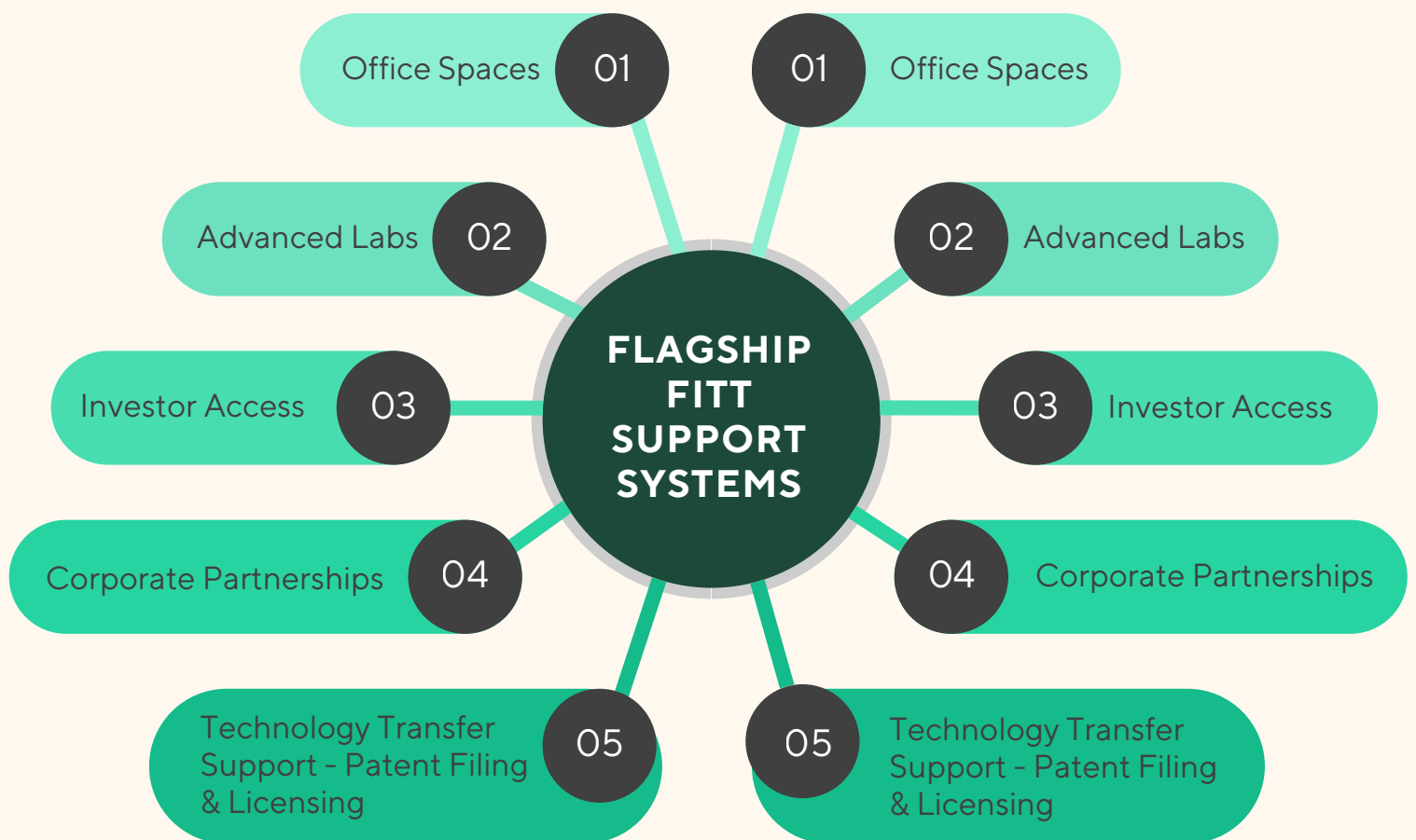
Even at the MVP stage, founders are introduced to basic go-to-market considerations. This ensures that MVP testing occurs in realistic environments rather than controlled or artificial settings, leading to more meaningful insights.

Building Quickly

Founders are encouraged to build fast and test early. Speed enables teams to move from uncertainty to clarity, helping them understand whether an idea is worth pursuing, pivoting, or abandoning.

Incubation and Scale-Up

Incubation at FITT - The Foundation for Innovation and Technology Transfer (FITT), IIT Delhi drives innovation by supporting startups through incubation, technology transfer, and market linkage, enabling ideas to scale into impactful ventures.



Youth and Beginner Track

Facilities, Help & Services at IIT Delhi

Bootcamps

- Access to IIT Delhi classrooms, seminar halls, and innovation spaces
- Structured modules by IIT faculty, FITT-linked mentors, and student entrepreneurs
- Hands-on activities using design thinking and startup toolkits

Workshops

- Conducted in labs, maker spaces, and collaborative learning rooms
- Support from technical societies, design clubs, and entrepreneurship cells
- Training in prototyping, pitching, customer discovery, and problem framing

Competitions

- Hosted on IIT Delhi platforms with institute-wide visibility
- Judging and feedback from industry experts, startup founders, and faculty
- Certificates, recognition, and pathway to incubation-oriented programs

Mentorship

- One-on-one and group mentoring by IIT alumni, founders, faculty, and senior students
- Guidance on idea validation, skills development, and career direction
- Continuous feedback through structured mentorship sessions

BSW Career Mentorship

- Career guidance via the Board for Student Welfare (BSW), IIT Delhi
- Peer-to-peer mentoring across core, tech, consulting, and startup roles
- Support in career exploration, decision-making, and long-term planning

Creativity

- Exposure to interdisciplinary environments and innovation-driven culture
- Encouragement through open ideation spaces, hackathons, and challenges
- Freedom to explore ideas beyond curriculum constraints

Leadership

- Opportunities to lead teams, initiatives, and projects within IIT ecosystems
- Training through student-led programs, events, and responsibilities
- Mentorship-driven leadership development

Teamwork

- Collaborative learning via group projects, competitions, and peer activities
- Diverse team exposure across backgrounds, skills, and interests
- Emphasis on communication and collective problem-solving

Confidence

- Safe, supportive environment to present ideas and experiment freely
- Regular exposure to public speaking, pitching, and feedback sessions
- Positive reinforcement through mentorship and peer learning

Your 7-Month Founder Journey

